

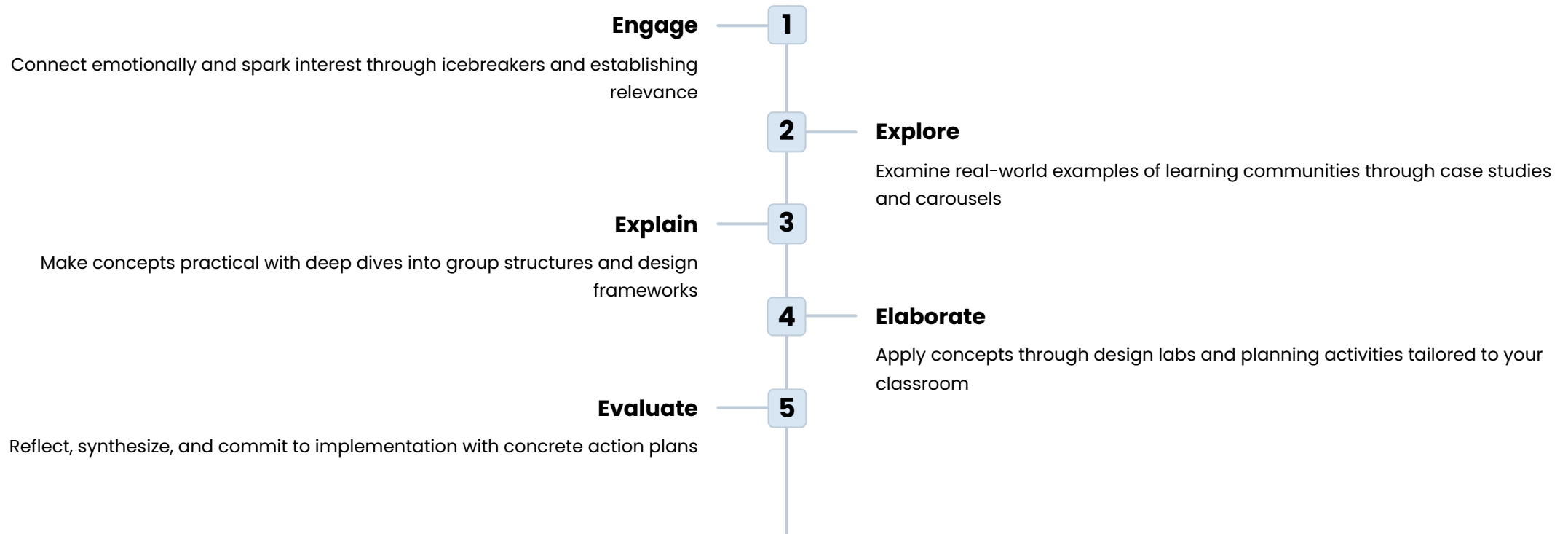


Cultivating Student Learning Communities in Upper Elementary

Empowering students through collaborative learning spaces that foster belonging, voice, and shared ownership of the learning process.

Workshop Overview

Today's professional development session follows the 5E instructional model to help you implement effective learning communities in your classroom.



Throughout our time together, you'll have opportunities to collaborate with peers, explore different models, and create tailored plans for implementation.

Workshop Objectives



Understand Learning Communities

Explore the role and importance of learning communities specifically designed for Grades 3–6 students and their unique developmental needs



Launch & Sustain Communities

Learn practical strategies to implement and maintain student-centered learning environments that evolve throughout the school year



Explore Age-Appropriate Models

Discover frameworks that effectively promote student voice, collaboration, and engagement for upper elementary learners



Create Tailored Action Plan

Develop a concrete implementation strategy customized for your specific classroom context and student population

Community Snapshots Gallery Walk



Reflect on a moment when your classroom truly felt like a community.

Consider these questions as you explore each station around the room:

- What specific elements made it feel like a true community?
- What were your students doing during this moment?
- What was your role as the teacher?
- What single word best captures that feeling?

After reflecting at each station, you'll share insights with a partner about what resonated with you.

☐ **Instructions:** Reflect silently for 2 minutes, then walk the room responding at each station with words or drawings. Afterward, pair up to discuss what stood out.

Gallery Walk

Implementation

For this 10-minute icebreaker activity, we'll establish four stations around the room to help teachers reconnect with meaningful classroom moments and build community among participants.

Station 1: Community Moments

Prompt: "Describe a moment when your class felt like a true community."

Station 2: Student Actions

Prompt: "What were students doing during that community moment?"

Station 3: Teacher Role

Prompt: "What were you doing as the teacher during that moment?"

Station 4: Feeling Word

Prompt: "What one word captures the feeling of that moment?"



Activity Flow:

1. Silent reflection (2 min)
2. Gallery walk responses (5 min)
3. Partner debrief (3 min)

This activity establishes an emotional connection to our topic while modeling a student-centered learning approach you can adapt for your classroom.

Why Learning Communities Matter

Students in collaborative learning environments show 50% greater gains in social-emotional skills and 37% improvement in academic achievement compared to traditional classroom models.

— Educational Psychology Review, 2022

Learning communities create the conditions for both academic success and social-emotional growth by shifting from teacher-centered to student-centered classrooms.

Foster Belonging

Create environments where every student feels valued and connected to peers

Encourage Voice

Provide authentic opportunities for student input and leadership

Strengthen Outcomes

Improve both academic achievement and social-emotional development

Empower Students

Develop leadership and collaboration skills through peer support

❓ **Reflection Question:** What specific challenge could a learning community help solve in your classroom?

What Is a Learning Community?

Collaborative Table Activity

Work with your table group to develop a shared understanding of learning communities in upper elementary classrooms.

1. Brainstorm key words and phrases that describe a learning community
2. Post your ideas directly to our shared Padlet (link on screen)
3. Use the collective word bank to craft a 1-2 sentence definition
4. Prepare to share your definition with the whole group

 **Tips:** Consider what students do, what teachers do, how it feels, and how communities evolve over time.

Key Elements to Consider:

- Student roles and responsibilities
- Teacher as facilitator vs. director
- Peer relationships and interactions
- Decision-making processes
- How community evolves over time

Case Study Gallery Walk

Exploring Real-World Learning Communities

Around the room, you'll find case studies from real upper elementary classrooms. Each highlights a different approach to building student learning communities.

Challenge

What problem or need was the teacher addressing?

Strategy

What community structure or model did they implement?

Outcomes

What were the results for students and classroom culture?

As you review each case study, consider: "What need was being met?" "What grouping model was used?" and "How could you adapt this idea for your classroom?"

Be prepared to share which approach resonated most with your context and why.

The Developmental Lens

Upper Elementary Students (Grades 3–6)

Understanding the developmental characteristics of 8–12 year olds helps us design learning communities that meet their unique needs and capitalize on their emerging capabilities.



Value Peer Relationships

Strong sense of fairness and increasing importance of friendships



Seek Leadership

Crave responsibility and opportunities to demonstrate competence



Need Structure

Respond well to clear routines while developing independence



Developing Empathy

Building capacity to understand others' perspectives



Implications for Communities:

- Mix grouping to foster adaptability
- Provide scaffolding and modeling
- Offer authentic leadership roles
- Balance structure with autonomy
- Create opportunities for diverse peer interactions

Models for Upper Elementary Learning Communities

Explore these flexible structures that promote student interdependence and agency while addressing developmental needs of grades 3–6.

Interest-Based Clubs

Self-selected groups formed around shared passions like reading circles, science explorers, or kindness clubs that meet regularly

Peer Mentorship Roles

Structured roles like reading buddies, tech helpers, and group facilitators that develop leadership and responsibility

Collaborative Projects

Time-bound teams working toward shared goals through class podcasts, school gardens, or inquiry fairs

Rotating Crews

Short-term communities that form around specific themes or roles (e.g., Publishing Team, Eco Week) with changing membership

The most effective classrooms often blend multiple models, adapting structures to meet different learning goals and student needs throughout the year.

The 5 Community Elements

These foundational elements work together to create thriving learning communities in upper elementary classrooms.



Community Elements Carousel

What makes a strong learning community?



Activity Instructions

01

Form Groups & Understand the Goal

Form small groups (3-4). Your goal is to explore 5 essential community elements at different stations and brainstorm classroom integration strategies.

02

Rotate Through Stations (10-12 minutes per station)

Rotate through 5 "Community Elements" stations. Read information, discuss relevance, envision strategies, and document key ideas.

03

Synthesize & Share Out (10-15 minutes)

Reconvene with your group. Synthesize insights across all elements and prepare to share 1-2 key takeaways or practical strategies.

Design Your Learning Community

Using Your Design Framework Template

Now it's time to apply what you've learned by designing a learning community tailored to your specific classroom context and student needs.

1

Purpose/Focus

What student needs will this community address? What's your vision for how it will function?

2

Student Roles

What responsibilities will students have? How will roles evolve or rotate over time?

3

Weekly Rhythm

What routines and structures will support this community? When and how often will activities occur?

4

Success Indicators

How will you know your learning community is working? What evidence will you look for?

✓ Design Tips:

- Start small and build gradually
- Involve students in the design process
- Plan for how the community will evolve
- Include regular reflection opportunities
- Consider both academic and social goals

After completing your design, you'll have time to receive feedback and refine your plan before committing to implementation steps.